PRI TZADDIK · PARSHAS TOLDOS · OIS GIMMEL

The King’s Table

Why Yitzchak ate before he blessed, and what that means for every meal we eat

By Akiva Gutnicki



Two meals stand at the center of Parshas Toldos, and they could not be more different.

In the first, a hungry hunter comes in from the field, gulps down a bowl of red lentils, and gets up and walks away. The Torah sums it up in five sharp verbs: *“He ate, he drank, he rose, he went, and he despised the birthright”* (Bereishis 25:34). The meal ends exactly where the hunger ends.

In the second, an old man who can no longer see asks his son for a dish of savory meat, *“the way I love it,”* so that his soul may bless him. He eats, he drinks wine, and out of that meal flow the blessings that shape Jewish history until today.

Same food. Same family. One meal closes a person off; the other opens him into a berachah. What is the difference? The answer takes us on a journey from the Ibn Ezra, through the Ramban, and into one of the most beautiful teachings of Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin, and from there, straight to our own kitchen tables.

The Ibn Ezra’s surprising chiddush: a poor house

Why would Esav sell something as precious as the birthright for a bowl of soup? The Ibn Ezra gives a startling answer. Esav despised the birthright because he saw that there was nothing in it. His father had no wealth.

He knows this sounds strange. Avraham left Yitzchak a great fortune! But, the Ibn Ezra says, we have all seen people born rich who end their lives poor. And then he lays out his evidence, piece by piece, like a lawyer:

Yitzchak loved Esav *because of the game he brought*. Had there been plenty of food in the house, would that matter? Had the household been comfortable, would the firstborn sell his birthright for stew? Why does Yitzchak have to ask for game at all? Why did Yaakov have no fine clothes of his own? Why did Rivkah send him off with no silver or gold, so that he had to pray, *“give me bread to eat and a garment to wear”*?

And when someone asks why Hashem would let a tzaddik like Yitzchak lose his wealth and his sight, the Ibn Ezra answers with real humility: do not brush it off with a flimsy derash. There is a mystery here. Hashem’s thoughts run deep, and human understanding cannot reach them.

It is a bold, very human reading. The great Yitzchak Avinu, son of Avraham, lives in a poor house, and the meal of game is precious to him precisely because there is so little else.

The Ramban objects, and offers his own peshat

The Ramban will have none of it. He quotes the Ibn Ezra at length, and then writes one of the sharpest lines in all of his commentary: *"Who blinded the eyes of his understanding in this matter?"*

Avraham left Yitzchak a huge fortune. Even if it had been lost, the Torah tells us that Yitzchak later grew exceedingly great in the land of the Pelishtim, until their princes envied him. Did he then fall back into poverty to crave a son's cooking? Hashem promised, "I will be with you and bless you," and "the blessing of Hashem is what makes one rich." The Avos were like kings; kings of nations came before them to make treaties. These are, says the Ramban, mere words of jest.

So why did Esav sell the birthright? The Ramban answers simply: because of the coarseness of his heart. After eating and drinking he went back to his hunting, and a man who risks his life every day in the field does not think about tomorrow. Fools want only to eat, drink and have what they want right now. In those days the birthright meant honor and precedence, not yet the Torah's double portion, and honor that might only come someday meant nothing to Esav.

And the game? Here the Ramban gives his peshat. Game was the food of princes and kings; the nations would bring it as tribute to those they honored. Esav courted his father by bringing it, and a father's love for his firstborn is easily won. But when Yitzchak asked for that food before the berachah, it was neither payment nor a bribe. The Ramban offers two explanations:

First, Yitzchak wanted to receive real pleasure from his son, *so that his soul would be bound to him in the moment of enjoyment*, and he could bless him with full desire and a whole heart.

Second, and this is the one to hold on to: perhaps Yitzchak knew his own soul. *After eating, it would take delight and rejoice, and the spirit of holiness would rest upon it*, just as Elisha asked for a musician before he prophesied, "and it came to pass, as the musician played, that the hand of Hashem came upon him" (II Melachim 3:15).

The meal, in other words, was a preparation for ruach hakodesh. That idea is a seed. Rav Tzadok will grow it into a tree.

Rav Tzadok: two kinds of meals

Rav Tzadok opens Ois Gimmel with something every Jew sings on Friday night. The Zohar calls the Shabbos meals by two names at once: the meal of faith and the meal of the King.

סְעוּדְתָא דִמְהֵימְנוּתָא … סְעוּדְתָא דְמַלְכָּא

"The meal of faith … the meal of the King" — Zohar II, 88b

Why two names? Because, Rav Tzadok explains, there are two kinds of holy eating.

The first is the *seudas mitzvah*, the meal of faith, eaten at the level of the tzaddik. Here the person eats as one standing before the King, filled with awe, so that bodily pleasure simply falls away. This is Rebbe, Rabbeinu HaKadosh, who said at the end of his life that he had not taken pleasure from this world even with his little finger, though his table never lacked for anything.

The second is higher still: the meal of the *chacham*, the meal of the King. Here the eating itself becomes holy, beyond the level of a mitzvah. The food is "the utterance of Hashem's mouth" within the bread, and the Torah scholar who eats it is offering a korban. That is why Chazal say that one who hosts a talmid chacham is like

one who brings the daily offerings, and one who wishes to pour wine on the altar should fill the throats of Torah scholars with wine. The table becomes, in the words of the navi, *"the table that is before Hashem"*.

Shabbos, says Rav Tzadok, carries both. It is a mitzvah to eat, so it is a meal of faith; and on Shabbos every Jew is like a Torah scholar, so it is the meal of the King.

The deeper meaning of the Ramban

Now return to Yitzchak. The Midrash says that when Yaakov told his father, "Hashem your God brought it before me," Yitzchak understood: if Hashem provided the ram for your offering at the Akeidah, how much more will He provide your food. Rav Tzadok reads this literally. Yitzchak's eating was truly korbanos, and even surpassed them.

That is why Rivkah tells Yaakov that Yitzchak will bless him *"before Hashem"*, words Yitzchak himself never said. Rivkah knew his level. His table was the table before Hashem. And yet Yitzchak, in his humility, did not claim this for himself. He asked only for food *"as I love,"* meaning, as Rav Tzadok explains, that he wanted every meal of his to be a seudas mitzvah.

Now the Ramban shines in a new light. The Ramban said the delight of the meal prepared Yitzchak for ruach hakodesh. Rav Tzadok shows us why. This was no ordinary pleasure that happened to lift his mood. It was the avodah of the altar. As he ate, the Shechinah rested upon him, and the berachos flowed from his mouth. The game was not a bribe and not a rich man's indulgence. It was a korban.

Rav Tzadok even finds the Yamim Tovim on that tray. The two kids Rivkah prepared, one view in the Zohar says, matched the Pesach and Chagigah, Avraham's love; the other says they matched the two goats of Yom Kippur. When Yaakov had to stand in his brother's clothes and speak words that were not quite true, his distress brought the awe and atonement of Yom Kippur into that meal. "These and those are the words of the living God."

Rav Tzadok's own table

This was not theory for Rav Tzadok. His biographer, R' Shmuel Unger, writes in Toldos HaKohen that after he became a chassid of the Ishbitzer, Rav Tzadok grew more and more exacting about when he ate. He stopped eating meat outside of a seudas mitzvah. Some chassidim went further, saying that he tasted nothing at all outside a seudas mitzvah, and so he made a siyum every single day. At that time, Unger records, he was reviewing all of Shas every two months.

Then comes the part of the story that moves me most. Rav Tzadok had stopped eating supper. When his rebbe heard, he directed him to eat an evening meal every night. Rav Tzadok obeyed, and from then on that supper counted as a seudas mitzvah, because his rebbe had told him to eat it. Chassidim remembered him saying, before he sat down:

הֲרֵינִי הוֹלֵךְ לְקַיֵּם מִצְוַת לִשְׁמֹעַ דִּבְרֵי חֲכָמִים

"I am going to fulfill the mitzvah of heeding the words of the sages" — Toldos HaKohen, ch. 6

Here is Yitzchak's *"as I love"* lived out in Lublin. A siyum gave the meal its occasion. A rebbe's word gave it another. Sitting down to eat became part of his avodah.

In his Kuntres Eis HaOchel, Rav Tzadok writes that eating in holiness can surpass even prayer, and that prophecy itself can come *"through eating and drinking, as written concerning Yitzchak."* He adds a line that could hang over every Jewish dining room:

אֶפְשָׁר לְאָדָם שֶׁיֹּאכַל כָּל מַעֲדַנֵּי עוֹלָם וְאַפִּילוּ הָכִי לֹא יֵהָנֶה מֵעוֹלָם הַזֶּה כְּלוּם

"A person can eat every delicacy in the world and still derive no pleasure at all from this world" — Eis HaOchel 6:1

That is Rebbe's table again: not a table of denial, but a table where the taste itself is experienced as the life Hashem gives through the food.

Waking the sleeper: one meal that lifts them all

In Eis HaOchel, ois 8, Rav Tzadok goes one step further, and it may be the most hopeful teaching in this whole sugya. He begins with a breathtaking claim:

כִּי בֶּאֱמֶת לַאֲמִתּוֹ, כָּל הָאֲכִילוֹת שֶׁל אִישׁ הַיִּשְׂרְאֵלִי הוּא דִּגְמַת הַקָּרְבָּנוֹת

"For in absolute truth, all the eating of a Jew is like the korbanos" — Eis HaOchel 8:1

Every meal. Not only the Shabbos seudah or the siyum. So what goes wrong? When the eating is not clarified by the intention of heart and mind, Rav Tzadok says, it *"resembles slumber."* This is the world of the *dvar reshus*, the permitted and ordinary. There is no sin in it at all; a person simply eats, drinks, works and rests, and treats it all as mundane. But Rav Tzadok calls that state sleep. He cites the Gemara that one who sits idle is like one who is asleep, and the pasuk, *"we were like dreamers."* A person, he warns, can sleep through all seventy years of his life if he never wakes from the slumber of time. He even notes that the permitted realm, kelipas nogah, is the secret of targum, which has the same gematria as tardeimah, deep sleep.

And then comes the good news. *"When he merits to awaken once from his sleep, he can repair all the slumbers."* The sleep itself is transformed: the Midrash says there are three kinds of tardeimah, and one of them is the sleep of prophecy. Just as the masters of Kabbalah taught that one true tefillah lifts up all the flawed tefillos of the entire year, a single meal in the week, or a Shabbos meal, eaten with the right intention for the sake of Heaven, elevates every meal a person has eaten:

מִתְעַלִּים כָּל הַמַּאֲכָלִים וְהַסְּעוּדוֹת שֶׁלּוֹ … וַאֲכִילָה גּוֹרֶרֶת אֲכִילָה לִהְיוֹת כְּמוֹתָהּ

"All his food and meals are elevated … and one meal draws another meal to become like it" — Eis HaOchel 8:1

Rav Tzadok applies the verse *"vayikatz kayashen,"* "He awoke like one who had been asleep": the sleeping part meets its own kind, fully awake, and it wakes up too. Like the korbanos, where a law of "drawing along" applies, one holy meal pulls the others along after it. And it is not only meals. One who awakens once can lift up all the permitted things he did before, and certainly the mitzvos he did without life or kavanah, by doing them once more with vitality and for the sake of Heaven.

Think about what that means. The meal does not only change what comes after it. It reaches back. The hundreds of meals we ate half asleep, standing at the counter, scrolling a phone, are not lost. They are waiting. And the first thing that wakes up is the person himself: the one who eats one meal awake discovers that he was never meant to be a sleeper at all.

Our avodah at the table

Most of us will not make a siyum every day or stop eating supper. But the path Rav Tzadok opens is not only for tzaddikim. Esav and Yitzchak ate the same kind of food. The difference was never what was on the plate. It was where the meal was going. Here is how we can start walking that path:

- **Let the berachah be a real sentence.** Rav Tzadok says the berachah before eating is what makes the table resemble an altar: the moment we recognize that Hashem gives the food its existence, its taste and its power to sustain us. Say one berachah a day slowly, word by word, and mean it.

- **Bring a few words of Torah to the table.** “Three who ate at one table and spoke words of Torah,” the Mishnah says, ate from the table of Hashem. It does not have to be a shiur. One idea from the parshah, one question for the kids, turns a dinner into the table before Hashem.
- **Turn ordinary meals into mitzvah meals.** Rav Tzadok found his occasions: a siyum, a rebbe’s instruction. We have ours too: a meal to strengthen ourselves for work or learning, a meal shared with a guest, a meal eaten in honor of Shabbos. Name the reason before you begin, and the meal has somewhere to go.
- **Wake up one meal this week.** You do not have to transform every meal at once. Choose one, perhaps a Shabbos seudah, and eat it fully awake: a berachah you mean, a word of Torah, a thought of who gave you this food and why. According to Eis HaOchel 8, that one meal reaches back and lifts all the others. Next week, choose two.
- **Let the weekday serve Shabbos.** Shammai would buy a fine animal for Shabbos, and if he found a better one, he kept the better one for Shabbos and ate the first. Even his weekday meal served Shabbos.
- **Eat to serve.** The Rambam writes that a person should sustain the body so that the mind can know Hashem and serve Him. Hillel lived by “Blessed is Hashem day by day,” caring for his body like a guest entrusted to him. Eating well is not the opposite of avodah; it can be avodah.
- **Set a place for someone else.** Chazal say that hosting a Torah scholar is like bringing the daily offerings, and the Gemara praises the one who lingers at the table so that someone in need can still eat. The surest way to make a table an altar is to feed another person from it.
- **Enjoy, with joy.** The Ramban’s Yitzchak took real delight in his meal, and that delight opened the door to ruach hakodesh. Rav Tzadok teaches that a permitted pleasure that leads into a mitzvah becomes simchah shel mitzvah. We do not have to choose between enjoying our food and serving Hashem.

From lentils to blessings

Esav ate, drank, rose and went, and despised. His meal ended at his stomach. Yitzchak ate and drank, and blessed, and his meal reached all the way to Heaven and to us. The Ibn Ezra looked at that meal and saw a poor man’s hunger. The Ramban saw a soul preparing for ruach hakodesh. Rav Tzadok saw an altar.

Tonight, when we sit down to eat, we get to choose which meal we are eating. Make a berachah you mean, share a word of Torah, invite someone to the table, and remember that the food in front of you carries the word of Hashem. Then your table, too, can become the King’s table, a table that is before Hashem.

Sources: Ibn Ezra and Ramban on Bereishis 25:34; Pri Tzaddik, Toldos, Ois Gimmel; Zohar II 88b; Avos 3:3; Bereishis Rabbah 65:19; II Melachim 3:15; R’ Shmuel Unger, Toldos HaKohen, ch. 6; Kuntres Eis HaOchel 6:1, 8:1; Avodah Zarah 65a; Tehillim 126:1; Beitzah 16a; Rambam, Hilchos De’os 3:2–3; Berachos 55a.